CORE FALSE BELIEF #4 · MY WORTH

“I am a failure.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

This belief often comes from high expectations, harsh criticism, or being compared with brothers, sisters, or classmates. It can take root after a major setback such as a divorce, a business loss, a lost job, or a broken promise to ourselves. Over time a person stops saying “I failed at that” and starts saying “I am a failure,” as though one chapter were the whole story.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is full of people who failed: Moses, David, Elijah, Peter, and many others. God did not discard them. He restored them and used them. The Bible says a righteous person may fall seven times and still get up. Paul learned that God’s power is made perfect in weakness. God’s mercies are new every morning. Failing at something is part of being human; it is not your identity. In Christ, failure becomes a place where grace can work.

> *“But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me”* (2 Corinthians 12:9).

Also see

> “For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times” (Proverbs 24:16).

> “Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!” (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> “Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God’s heavenly calling in Christ Jesus” (Philippians 3:13–14).

> “The steps of a man are ordered by the LORD who takes delight in his journey. Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand” (Psalm 37:23–24).

Common self-statements

- I never get anything right.
- Everyone else succeeds; I don’t.
- Why try? I will only fail again.
- I have wasted my life.
- I let everyone down.
- One mistake ruins everything.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Turning “I failed” into “I am a failure.”
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that anything less than complete success is total failure.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will fail before I even try.
- Mental filter: Remembering my failures and forgetting what I have done well.

Challenging questions

- What exactly did I fail at, and is that the same as being a failure?
- What have I done well, even in small ways?
- Who taught me that mistakes make me a failure?
- How did God treat Peter, David, or Moses after they failed?
- What did I learn from this failure?
- What is one small next step I can take?

Truth summary

> I have failed at some things, like every person who has ever lived. But a failure is something that happened, not who I am. God restores people who fall, and His grace is enough for me. I can get up, learn, and take the next step with His help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Weakness
- Grace
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Strength
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Hello My Name Is — Matthew West
God's redeemed-child identity challenges labels of regret and defeat.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am a failure"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I am a failure." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I fail at, specifically?
- ☐ What have I done well?
- ☐ Who taught me mistakes make me a failure?
- ☐ How did God treat people in the Bible who failed?
- ☐ What did I learn?
- ☐ What small next step can I take?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Failing is not the same as being a failure.
- ☐ God's grace is enough for me.
- ☐ His mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ The righteous fall and get up again.
- ☐ I can learn from mistakes.
- ☐ God is not finished with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **2 Corinthians 12:9**
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."
- ☐ **Proverbs 24:16**
  "For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times."
- ☐ **Lamentations 3:22–23**
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I tried and what I learned: Each day, write one thing you attempted, how it went, and one thing you learned, whether it succeeded or not.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 12:9 becomes: "Mark can write: "God's grace is enough for me. My weakness is where His power can work.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Change the label. Write "I am a failure." Then rewrite it as a specific event: "I failed at ___ on ___." Notice the difference.
- [ ] List what you have done well. Write ten things you have accomplished or done faithfully, large or small. Ask someone who knows you to add two.
- [ ] Try something small. Choose one small task you have been avoiding because you might fail. Do it this week and note what happened.
- [ ] Read a restoration story. Read John 21:15–19, where Jesus restores Peter. Write what it tells you about how God treats failure.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I am a failure": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Something I tried
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I am a failure.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have failed many times, and I have let failure tell me who I am. Thank You that Your grace is enough and that Your power works in my weakness. Help me get up, learn, and keep walking with You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.